

>> Sound Unbound

Tom Cruise is trying to escape the authorities, but they aren't giving up on him. Their footsteps echo on the metal floor. One of them gets his hand on Cruise, but gets a fist in his face instead. Thump. Tom picks up the shockwave gun dropped by him and loads it up. A metallic creaking sound emanates as he loads, and fires it. A deep rumbling sound rattles the glass windows. Had it not been for the pillow that you tore to bits in sheer excitement, you would not have known that you are in the confines of your room! Cruise shot shockwaves right in front of you! This is exactly the kind of experience you should expect from a

good speaker set—sound that fills your senses and overwhelms you. Be it music, movies or games, anything will sound good, provided you have the right set of speakers. And this month we help you make a sound choice.

We didn't include 2.1 systems, as they can't really be compared to the quality of, say, a 4.1 or 5.1 system. We have top-of-the-line PC speakers, ranging from the Altec Lansing 641 in the 4.1 category, to the Megaworks in the 5.1, and the Creative Inspire T7700 in the 7.1 category. Go through our comparison, and get rid of those tinny stubs sitting on your desktop.



4.1 SPEAKERS

We tested 14 speakers in the 4.1 category, including the popular picks, and even the select expensive ones. Let's take a look at how they fared.

Performance

Sure, it's great to have FM radio or remote controls, but what really matters is the quality of sound. So let's put aside the features, documentation and ease of use for later, and jump straight to the performance scores.

In our gaming tests, the Creative Inspire shone, and though the Odyssey and the Artis speakers performed decently, they couldn't match Creative in the boom and thump department. The Intex IT 2600W speakers were disappointing, and *Quake III* sounded more like *Quack III* on them. The rest were just about average. Most of the speakers lacked full-bodied, ambient

atmospheric sounds—the sounds were just tinny and sharp. Another reason for the dismal performance is that most of these speakers are pseudo 4.1—they don't actually have four discreet channels, but instead replicate the two stereo channels in both the front and rear speakers, which just isn't enough for gaming.

Almost all the speakers were washouts in the movie test, barring the superb Creative set, the Philips and the Odyssey. The Philips made up for its poor gaming scores with good sound quality for movies. The Odyssey also performed well here, but the Creative was the best again.

Now for the real meat of the tests—the music tests. The Artis played *With or without you* by U2 beautifully, with bass that was tight and punchy, and no booming. The Creative subwoofer failed and started distorting at higher volumes—it gave up long before the Artis could even show signs of distortion. Though not considered to be in the class of Artis or Creative, the Adcom also did pretty well with this song. It needs to improve its gaming and movie performances tremendously, though.

The Artis stayed in the lead for *Bullet the blue sky*, also by U2—the mids stayed sharp, and didn't go muddy (mixing of the mids and highs) at higher volumes. Both, the Adcom and Creative Inspire, went muddy at higher volumes. There was also a high amount of distortion evident with most of the speakers when playing this song. Even the Philips wasn't able to do the song justice.

For the both the Hindi songs—film music and the classical piece—



Here's the entire 4.1 range of speakers, lined up for a photo shoot